

celebrated work—and four years later accepted the post of music director for the princess of Lucca, Napoleon’s sister. He left the court appointment in 1809 to become a traveling solo performer-composer. His fame spread from the early 1800s, along with his reputation for womanizing and indulging in drink.

**“This Satan who ruled over the lush dreams
of the female sex.”**

KLAUS KINSKI, IN HIS FILM PAGANINI, 1989

In 1820 Paganini developed serious health issues, including a persistent cough, for which he was prescribed opium. Around three years later, syphilis was diagnosed (probably contracted when he was just 22), which was treated, according to him, with “murderous doses” of mercury—after which, his teeth loosened and eventually fell out, his eyesight and handwriting began to fail, and he suffered gastrointestinal problems as well as a host of other horrific maladies that worsened with age. But in 1824, he fell in love with the singer Antonia Bianchi and the following year they had a son, Achille. The relationship lasted just four years; Antonia was handsomely paid off, and Achille stayed with his father.